

UNION GENERAL (1824-1902)

FRANZ SIGEL



Franz Sigel emigrated from Germany after fighting in the unsuccessful revolution of 1848. By 1860 he was a prominent member of the German community in St. Louis, Missouri, working as an educator and well-known for his anti-slavery views. From the start of the war he did much to recruit German-Americans for the Union forces, but was less successful as a general. He did play a major role in the Union success at Pea Ridge (Elkhorn Tavern) in 1861, but later failed as a corps commander with the Army of the Potomac and when given an independent command in the Shenandoah Valley.

Mixed reactions

German-Americans felt the sting of a resurgent nativism after the Battle of Chancellorsville, in which the Northern public placed most of the blame for the Union defeat on the shoulders of the German Eleventh Corps (the successor organization to Blenker's Division). Outraged at what they perceived as unfair aspersions and ugly lampooning, German-born Northerners questioned their participation in the war and began to turn inward, toward themselves and their ethnic communities, for sympathy and support. The supply of recruits for the German regiments also dried up, although most German units fought on much as before through the end of the war, commanded by German officers but diluted by non-German draftees. For the ethnic communities of the North, nothing was the same after the summer of 1863.

In the end, 25 percent of all Union soldiers were born overseas, most of them in Germany or Ireland. Most of these men served in nonethnic regiments, bolstering the strength of these units as the war dragged on. Without them, the North would have been hard-pressed to secure victory.